

Seawall height in North Palm Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

NORTH PALM BEACH • PALM BEACH COUNTY

4 ft NAVD88

New and substantially rebuilt seawalls in North Palm Beach need a cap at least 4 ft NAVD88, or 5 ft NAVD88 on the Intracoastal, Lake Worth or the ocean in a FEMA flood zone. Repairs under 50% of replacement cost are exempt.

The detail

ZONE X / X500	Min 4 ft NAVD88; max 6 in. above grade or 4.5 ft NAVD88, whichever is greater - Sec. 5-72(3)
FEMA SFHA/CHHA WITH BFE	Min 4 ft NAVD88; max 6 in. above grade or 5 ft NAVD88, whichever is greater - Sec. 5-72(3)
SFHA/CHHA ON INTRACOASTAL, LAKE WORTH OR ATLANTIC	Min 5 ft NAVD88; max 6 in. above grade or 6 ft NAVD88, or up to BFE with approved mitigation - Sec. 5-72(3)
APPLIES TO	New walls and repairs costing 50% or more of replacement cost - Sec. 5-72
RETURNS	Cap above neighbor grade needs a matching wall return - Sec. 5-72(4)
WHO REVIEWS	Plans sealed by a Florida-registered engineer; the village engineer reviews every seawall repair or reconstruction application for structural integrity - Sec. 5-70, 5-73(1)
SOIL BORING	The permit needs a Standard Penetration Test boring by a Florida geotechnical engineer, drilled at least 5 ft below the deepest wall component, plus proof concrete meets ACI 318 Exposure Class C2 - Sec. 5-73(1)(b), (g)
CAP AND POSITION	The cap may extend no more than 3 ft from the wet face or rear property line; a rebuilt wall may sit up to 18 in. waterside of the property line, further only by council fill permit - Sec. 5-72(1)-(2)
DOCK DECK	Main deck between 2.5 ft NAVD88 and the height of the adjacent seawall cap - Sec. 5-83(b)

Where this comes from: Village of North Palm Beach Code, Ch. 5 Boats, Docks and Waterways, Art. III Div. 3, Sec. 5-72 (Ord. 2019-07; Ord. 2026-02, 1-22-26); Secs. 5-70, 5-73, 5-83

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.